BuildRight Construction - Scaffolding and Work at Height Procedure

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1. Definitions and hierarchy of controls

Work at height means any work where a person could fall a distance liable to cause injury, including work on scaffolds, ladders, roofs, mobile elevating work platforms (MEWPs) and near unprotected edges or openings.

Falls from height are the first cause of fatal accidents in construction. Before any work at height, the supervisor must apply the following hierarchy:

1. Avoid work at height where possible (assemble at ground level, use long-reach tools).

2. Use collective protection that prevents falls: guardrails, scaffolds, MEWPs, covers over openings.

3. Use collective protection that limits the consequences of a fall: safety nets, airbags.

4. Only as a last resort, use personal fall arrest systems (harness and lanyard).

2. Fall protection threshold

Fall protection is mandatory for any work where a worker could fall 2 metres or more to a lower level. Regardless of height, fall protection is always required when working above dangerous equipment, water, or protruding rebar, or near openings in floors.

Floor openings larger than 30 cm must be covered by a secured cover able to support twice the expected load and marked "HOLE - DO NOT REMOVE", or protected by guardrails on all sides.

3. Guardrail specifications

A compliant guardrail system consists of:
- a top rail at a height between 1.0 m and 1.1 m above the working surface;
- an intermediate rail (mid-rail) placed halfway between the top rail and the toe board, so that no gap exceeds 47 cm;
- a toe board at least 15 cm high to prevent tools and materials from falling.

The top rail must withstand a force of at least 0.9 kN (about 90 kg) applied in any direction without failing.

4. Scaffolds - general requirements

Scaffolds may only be erected, modified and dismantled by trained and competent scaffolders, under the supervision of a person who has followed scaffold supervision training. Users must never remove or modify any part of a scaffold (guardrail, tie, brace, board). If a modification is needed, request it from the scaffolding team.

Guardrails on scaffolds: guardrails (top rail, mid-rail and toe board as defined in section 3) are mandatory on all open sides and ends of every scaffold platform where the platform is 2 metres or more above the lower level. Below 2 metres, guardrails are still recommended and are mandatory if the scaffold is placed next to an excavation, a road or any other specific hazard identified in the risk assessment.

Platforms must be fully boarded, at least 60 cm wide, and boards must not overhang their supports by more than 30 cm or less than 15 cm. The gap between the platform and the building face must not exceed 30 cm, otherwise an inner guardrail is required.

Scaffolds must be tied to the structure according to the design. Freestanding tower scaffolds must respect the height-to-base ratio given by the manufacturer (typically 3.5 to 1 outdoors) and have outriggers fitted where required.

Access to scaffold platforms must be by internal stairs or by ladders secured at the top, extending at least 1 metre above the landing. Climbing the scaffold frame is forbidden.

5. Scaffold inspection and tagging

A scaffold must be inspected by a competent person:
- before first use, after erection;
- at least every 7 days while in use;
- after any event likely to affect its stability (strong wind above 50 km/h, impact by a vehicle, modification, heavy rain or frost).

The result is recorded in the scaffold register and shown by a tag at each access point: GREEN tag "Safe for use", YELLOW tag "Modified - special conditions apply, read the tag", RED tag "Do not use - incomplete or unsafe". Never use a scaffold without a valid green tag or with a red tag.

Maximum load: platforms must not be overloaded. The safe working load (in kg/m2) is written on the green tag. Light-duty scaffolds (class 3) are limited to 200 kg/m2.

6. Ladders

Ladders are only allowed for short-duration work (less than 30 minutes in the same position) and light tasks, or as a means of access. Ladders must be set at an angle of 75 degrees (1 unit out for every 4 units up), stand on a firm level base, and be secured against slipping. Always maintain three points of contact. Never stand on the top three rungs. Metal ladders must not be used near electrical installations.

7. Mobile elevating work platforms (MEWPs)

Only trained operators holding a valid MEWP licence may operate a MEWP. A harness with a short restraint lanyard attached to the designated anchor point in the basket is mandatory in boom-type MEWPs. A ground rescue person trained in emergency lowering must be present whenever the platform is in use. MEWPs must not be used in winds above 45 km/h or the limit specified by the manufacturer, whichever is lower.

8. Personal fall arrest systems

When used, a personal fall arrest system must include a full body harness, an energy absorber, and an anchor point with a strength of at least 10 kN (EN 795). The anchor point must be above the worker whenever possible. The free fall distance must be limited so that the worker does not hit the ground or an obstacle: check the clearance required (typically at least 6 metres below the anchor point for a 2-metre lanyard with energy absorber).

Workers must never work alone when using a fall arrest system. A written rescue plan must exist before work starts: a worker suspended in a harness must be rescued within 15 minutes because of the risk of suspension trauma.

9. Roof work

Work on roofs requires edge protection on all open edges. Fragile roofs (fibre cement sheets, skylights, old roof lights) must never be walked on directly: use crawling boards and safety nets under the work area. Roof work stops in rain, ice or winds above 50 km/h.

10. Training

All workers who work at height receive work-at-height training at induction and a refresher every 3 years. Harness users receive practical harness training, including inspection and rescue, every 2 years.